

A daily scan of national and South Yorkshire developments in education policy, inclusion, SEND, behaviour and accountability — weighted to primary and evidence sources, with links and a clear “so what for your school” line on the items that matter.

Useful? Forward it to a colleague. To join the circulation or partner with the network, [get in touch](#).

TOP LINE

- The government has confirmed the biggest overhaul of school food standards in over a decade — capping high fat, salt and sugar foods and requiring more fresh fruit, veg and wholegrains — with schools given a year to prepare before the rules bite in September 2027.
→ **For your school:** A long lead-in, but worth flagging to catering and finance teams now given the scale of the menu changes required.
- Ofsted's latest round of Sheffield inspections (rounded up by The Star this week) is a mixed bag: praise for schools like Swallownest Primary and Bankwood Community, but a critical report for Stocksbridge High School over attendance and outcomes for disadvantaged pupils.
→ **For your school:** A useful local comparator if you're benchmarking attendance or disadvantage-gap language in your own SEF.

DATES FOR THE DIARY

18 Sep 2026 — DfE's twin SEND/EOTAS reform consultations close — last call to respond before proposals are firmed up.

NATIONAL POLICY & FUNDING

- **Biggest school food shake-up in a decade.** New standards will limit food and drink high in fat, salt and sugar and put more fresh fruit, vegetables and wholegrains on every plate. Schools have a year to prepare before the rules take effect in September 2027, with some secondary-specific measures phased in by 2028. (GOV.UK)
→ **For your school:** Long lead-in, but a good moment to start the catering-contract conversation.

SHEFFIELD & SOUTH YORKSHIRE

- **Nine Sheffield schools and nurseries get fresh Ofsted ratings.** The Star's latest roundup covers inspections from the summer through to the first week of September: Swallownest Primary and Bankwood Community were both praised, while Stocksbridge High School was criticised over 'unacceptable' attendance and disadvantaged pupils leaving without basic qualifications. ([The Star](#))
→ **For your school:** Worth a read if any partner schools are due inspection soon — a live sense of what's landing hardest under the current framework.

SAFEGUARDING & WELLBEING

- **Thirlwall Inquiry's final report published.** The inquiry into failures at the Countess of Chester Hospital reported this week; the Health Secretary called it "thorough and devastating" and pledged action on whistleblowing and information-sharing failures. It's an NHS story, not a schools one, but it lands the same week the DfE's own information-sharing duty comes into focus ahead of its 30 September commencement. (GOV.UK)

→ **For your school:** Not schools-specific, but useful background if your safeguarding lead is reviewing how concerns get escalated and shared across agencies.

JARGON-BUSTER - EOTAS

Cropping up a lot as the DfE's SEND consultations close this Friday.

"Education Otherwise Than At School" — the legal route for children who can't attend a mainstream or special school placement. The current consultation asks whether it should also cover some children no longer eligible for an EHCP.

MAPS IN PRACTICE – TOOL SPOTLIGHT: SCHOOL+

A strong inclusion strategy is only as good as the cohort picture beneath it.

School+ is the MAPs cohort-vulnerability framework — it maps who your at-risk pupils are and why, giving your inclusion strategy an evidence base rather than a wish list. [Explore School+](#)

SOURCES MONITORED

Weighted official- and evidence-first. X is monitored for early signals from official accounts and named commentators, and corroborated against a primary source before anything is included.

Source	Type	What we track
OFFICIAL & STATUTORY		
DfE / GOV.UK	Government	Policy, funding, statutory guidance and statistics
Ofsted	Government	Inspection framework, report cards, annual report
Explore Education Statistics	Government data	Exclusions, suspensions, attendance, census data
House of Commons Library	Parliament	Neutral briefings on bills and policy
RESEARCH & EVIDENCE		
Education Endowment Foundation	Research	Evidence-based guidance, incl. inclusive teaching
NFER	Research	Assessment, workforce, disadvantage
Education Policy Institute	Think tank	Policy analysis and the disadvantage gap
Institute for Fiscal Studies	Think tank	School funding and spending analysis
FFT Education Datalab	Data analysis	Data-driven analysis of attainment and exclusions
INCLUSION & PREVENTION SPECIALISTS		
The Difference	Charity	Whole-school inclusion; "Who's Losing Learning?"
IPPR	Think tank	Lost learning, exclusions, SEND reform
Youth Endowment Fund	Research	What works to prevent youth violence & exclusion
Centre for Social Justice	Think tank	Exclusion tracker and social-mobility policy
Whole School SEND	Network	SEND practice, resources and reviews
SECTOR PRESS & COMMENTARY		
Schools Week	Press	Breaking sector news and investigations
Tes	Press	Practice, policy and workforce
The Guardian (Education)	Press	National coverage and comment
X (monitored)	Social	DfE, Ofsted, EEF and named voices — corroborated before use
LOCAL & REGIONAL		
The Star (Sheffield)	Local press	Local schools and Ofsted outcomes
Sheffield City Council	Local government	Council decisions, funding and local strategy
South Yorkshire MCA & Careers Hub	Regional	Regional skills, careers and funding

Connect Daily is part of Sheffield Connect. Compiled by Andy Marsden, Sector Inclusion Lead.

For circulation across the network and partners. Figures reflect the latest published data at the date of this brief.